Exploring Summer in WLC Schools:

A Landscape Analysis of
Programs, Purpose, Challenges, and Future Implications

WLC

August 15, 2025

Problem Statement & Project Vision

Problem Statement:

The WLC has allocated approximately **$1.5 million** to support summer learning across nine schools in summer 2025. However, the organization **lacks a data-driven approach** that incorporates the perspectives of key stakeholders—ranging from program coordinators to families. Without these voices, the WLC **cannot fully understand the effectiveness of its funding efforts**, which ultimately **hinders future funding and planning strategies**.

Project Vision:

This study aims to conduct a mixed-methods landscape analysis to explore how programs are being implemented on the ground from multiple perspectives, using a student- and family-centered approach.

OKR (Objectives and Key Results)

Objective:

We **identify the most critical challenges** faced by key stakeholders in summer learning programs and **offer recommendations** to improve their experience when delivering future programs.

KEY RESULT #1

Execute program observations to all summer learning program at the 9 schools and interview program staff **to identify 3-4 reoccurring pain points** in program planning and execution.

KEY RESULT #2

Collect quantitative data from schools and district office **to uncover funding breakdown** and **student engagement trend** in summer learning (ie. total enrollment, average daily attendance rate, program length).

KEY RESULT #3

Conduct online survey to families which generates at least 200 responses **to develop recommendations that will improve family experience** in summer learning.

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Research Questions

Q1 **What summer learning experiences are currently offered at the nine partner schools, and what makes each unique?**

This question seeks to understand the **types of programs** offered at each site, **who is delivering** them, **who they serve**, **how many students** participate, **the number of staff** supporting them, and the **program timelines**.

Q2 **What challenges and gaps do program coordinators, district leaders, and families perceive in the current summer learning offerings?**

We aim to understand how the voices of instructors, coordinators, and families are incorporated into planning and decision-making for summer programming.

Q3 **What opportunities and recommendations should the Wilmington Learning Collaborative (WLC), program-level leaders, and district leadership consider to better serve students and their families in future summers?**

This includes exploring the extent to which current support systems meet stakeholder needs, identifying unmet needs, and determining how districts and partners can be better supported.

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Methodology

Program Level

Program Observation
15 program observations were conducted over the course of one month to gain rich, contextual insights into how programs were executed on the ground.

Unstructured Interview
Interviews were conducted with instructors and program coordinators during each site visits.

Family Level

Survey (n=194)
A bilingual (English & Spanish) 13-question survey was distributed to families with students in the nine WLC schools to gather feedback on their children's summer plans and experiences.

District Level

Semi-Structured Interview
6 interviews were conducted via phone or video call with program directors, district leaders, and summer learning coordinators to collect district-level insights into summer program planning and execution.

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Insight

-Program Overview

Program Overview

Total Programs	18
Total Funding from WLC	$1,472,436.72
Total Student Served	1257
Total Program Staffs	279
Total Average Attendance	694
Average Daily Attendance	57.30%
Average Program Length	113.4 hours
Average Program Length	5.1 weeks
Average Program Start Date	July 2, 2025
Average Program End Date	August 3, 2025



Program Overview (cont.)

Program Name	School	District	Funding	Program Hours	Student Enrolled	Daily Average Student Attendance	Attendance Rate	Number of Staff	Student-Staff Ratio
Freedom School	Maurice Pritchett Sr. Academy	Christina	$253,398.80	110	85	52	61.18%	12	4.3:1
Freedom School	The Bayard School	Christina		110	92	59	64.13%	13	4.5:1
REACH Program	Maurice Pritchett Sr. Academy	Christina	Not being funded by WLC	110	10	7	70.00%	8	0.9:1
Enrichment	Maurice Pritchett Sr. Academy	Christina	$218,954.40	110	81	35	43.21%	8	4.4:1
Extended School Year (ESY)	Pulaski Early Education Center	Christina		70	11	10	90.91%	2	5:1
Entitlement	Pulaski Early Education Center	Christina		110	28	15	53.57%	4	3.8:1
Entitlement	The Bayard School	Christina		110	21	9	42.86%	16	0.6:1
Extended School Year (ESY)	The Bayard School	Christina		70	29	17	58.62%	12	1.4:1
Enrichment	The Bayard School	Christina		110	87	40	45.98%	13	3.1:1
21st Century (United Way)	Pulaski Early Education Center	Christina	Not being funded by WLC	110	40	18	45.00%	9	2:1
21st Century (United Way)	Maurice Pritchett Sr. Academy	Christina	Not being funded by WLC	110	73	38	52.05%	10	3.8:1
YMCA	Pulaski Early Learner)	Christina	$208,652	180	47	26	55.32%	10	2.6:1
	Harlan Summer Academy								
	Harlan Elementary School	Brandywine							

Funding	Program Hours	Student Enrolled	Daily Average Student Attendance	Attendance Rate	Number of Staff	Student-Staff Ratio
$150,000						
$397,859	156	200	110	55.00%	21	5.2:1
$153,985.40	125	58	40	68.97%	66	0.6:1
$41,255.12	120	60	34	56.67%	10	3.4:1
Not being funded by WLC	60	148	62	41.89%	40	1.6:1
Not being funded by WLC	60	37	22	59.46%	5	4.4:1
$48,332	210	150	100	66.67%	20	5:1

Insight

-Challenges

Initial Discovery: Low Student Attendance

One of the most immediate findings from the quantitative data was a surprisingly low average student attendance rate of just 57% across the 18 summer programs.

This statistic raises an important question:

What does such low attendance indicate? In financial terms, it suggests that nearly half of the allocated funding is not being fully utilized to reach students—raising concerns about the return on investment (ROI) for these programs.

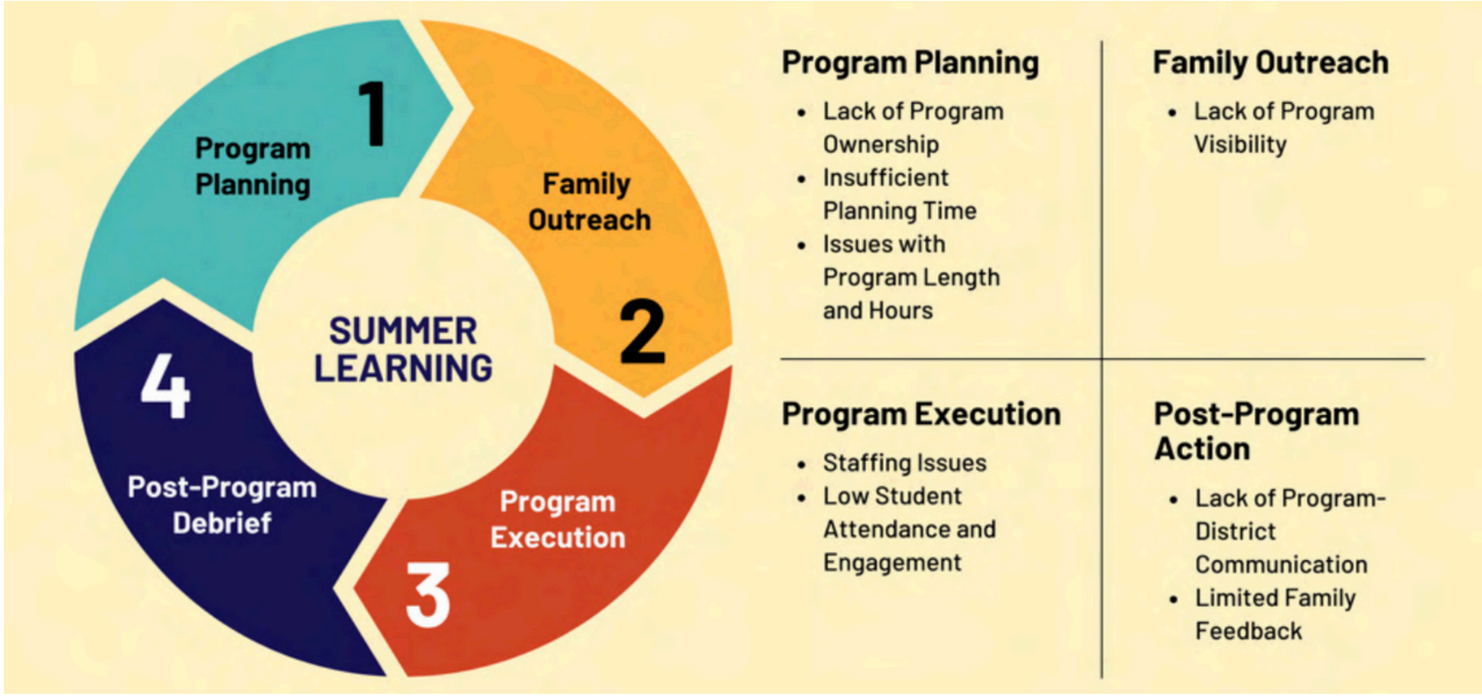
More importantly, the low attendance rate prompted further inquiry:

- **Why are students not attending summer programs consistently?**
- **What barriers are preventing higher participation?**
- **What challenges are stakeholders facing during program planning and execution that may contribute to these attendance issues?**

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Challenges

Data has shown a variety of overarching challenges affecting districts and summer learning programs. To better illustrate how these issues appear across the program lifecycle, we have organized the challenges into four categories: **program planning**, **family outreach**, **program execution**, and **post-program action**.



Program Planning

Lack of Program Ownership

The lack of communication between school-based program coordinators and district-level staff was one of the most frequently cited challenges during interviews and program visits. This issue showed up in two main ways:

Unclear Distribution of Responsibilities

Lack of Consistent Communication Touchpoints

> **I think there just needs to be more frequent communication with our community partners to make sure we're all on the same page, getting them information as early as we can, and then designing their attendance sheets, their classroom assignments, things like that, and getting that back to us before the first day of the program.**"
>
> - District Summer Program Coordinator

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Program Planning (cont.)

Insufficient Planning Time

Summer learning is often not treated as an extension of the school year and is typically not prioritized during the fall and spring semesters. This compressed timeline leads to several operational challenges:

Limited Time for Cross-Program Coordination

Smaller Programs Overlooked in Planning

> **In a 1st-grade classroom, students were watching a cartoon on the smartboard while the instructor—visibly stressed—scrambled to create individual lesson plans. "I don't have access to anything!" she said. Because she wasn't a regular teacher at the school, she had no access to student profiles or IEPs and had been unable to contact in-year instructors.**
>
> - Field note

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Program Planning (cont.)

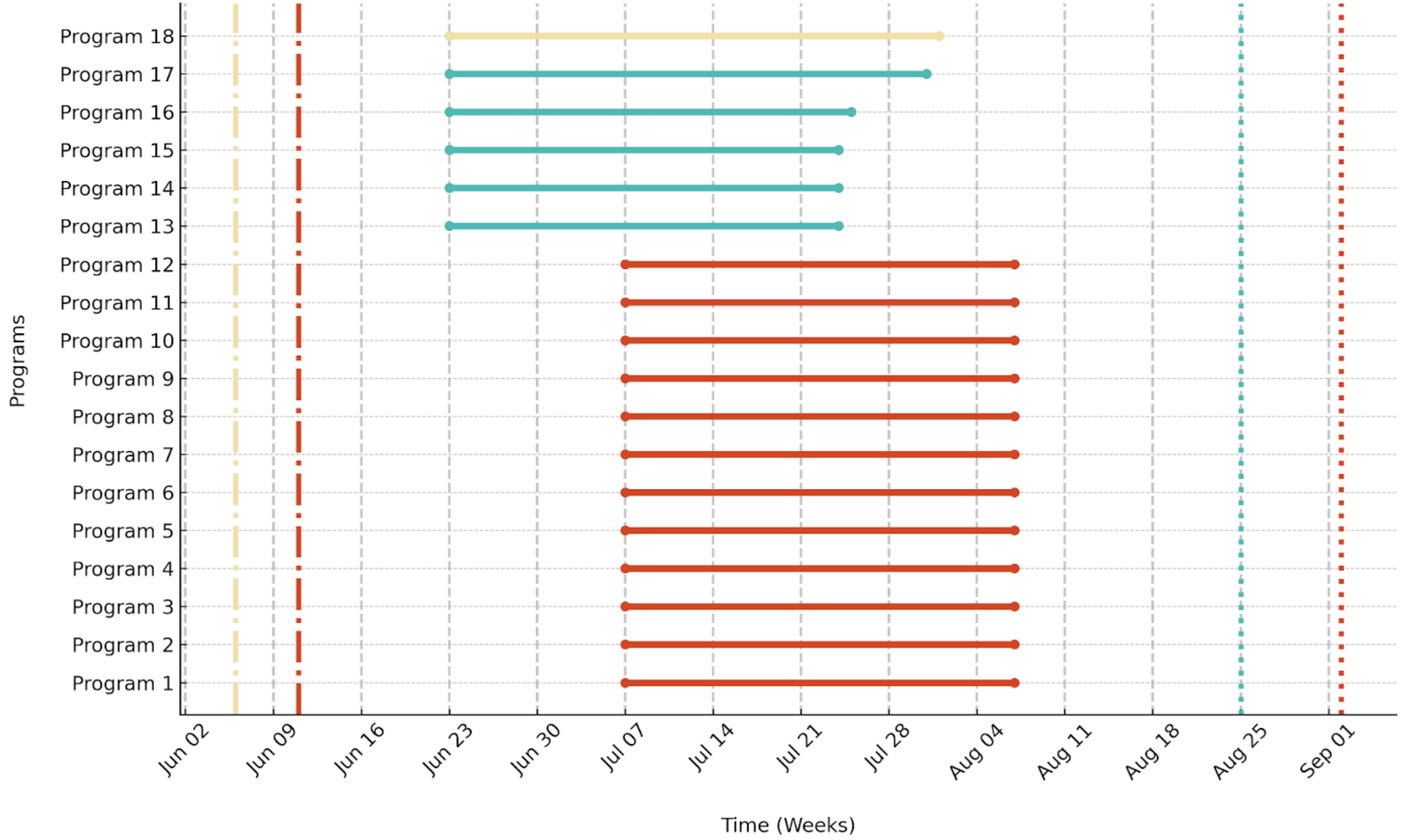
Program Length and Hours

The average program lasted five weeks, running from July 2 to August 3. However, this covered only about half of students' full summer break. Many working families struggled to find childcare and alternative options during the weeks before and after the program.

> **The only challenge my family faced was adjusting to the program's hours. Making sure we could adjust our work schedules to pick my student up on time so she would not be kicked out."**
>
> - Parent

> **I recommend extended hours. It's more feasible for working families. Also the time placement of the program. Maybe have it more towards the end of July into August to have flow seamlessly into the school year."**
>
> - Parent

2025 WLC Summer Program Timeline (Categorized by School District)



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Family Outreach

Lack of Program Visibility

Engaging families in summer program planning and participation proved to be a significant challenge. While schools and districts made efforts to share registration information, many families remained unaware of the full range of offerings—or misunderstood which programs their children were enrolled in.

Survey data has found that only 5% of families learned about summer programs through social media, 6% via online search, and 14% from flyers or posters

> **There was limited information provided at sign up about the camp itself. Several weeks after registering and I hadn't received a confirmation/acceptance notice I called to double check the status of my son's enrollment."**
>
> - Parent

Program Execution

Staffing

Staffing emerged as the most persistent and foundational challenge across nearly every site. Key issues included:

Inadequate Compensation

Lack of Preparedness and Support

Limited Backup or Relief Staff

> **I was getting paid less and expected to do more. You see why people are leaving. Don’t you?”**
>
> - 4th Grade Summer Instructor

Program Execution (cont.)

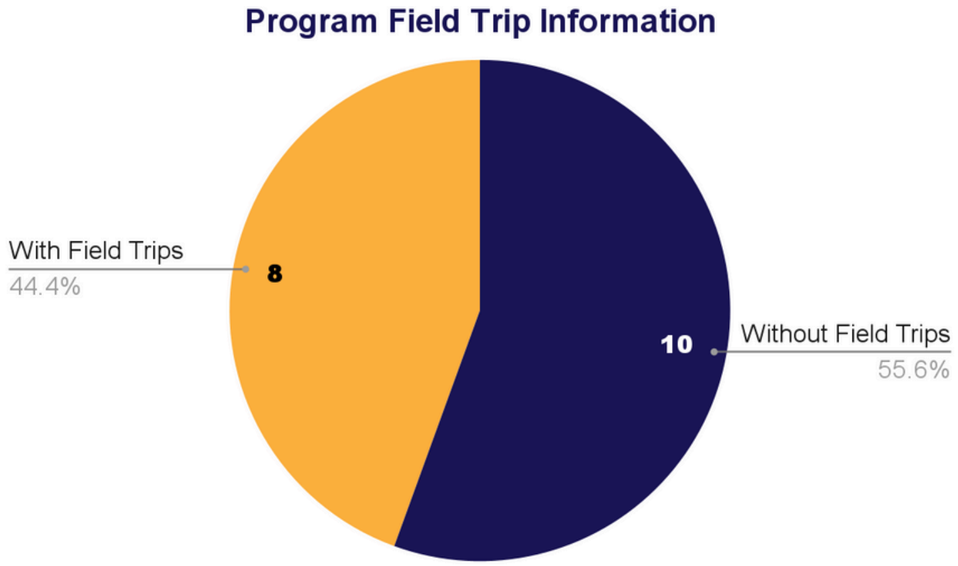
Low Student Attendance & Engagement

Data has revealed widespread concerns about student engagement—particularly among older students, such as those in the final years of middle school. Several key issues contributed to these challenges:

Mandatory Enrollment Without Motivation

Limited Enrichment Activities & Lack of Field Trips

Lack of Student-Centered Design



> **It's like summer school, but they get to have fun as well. Most importantly, offering field trips free of cost so kids that have busy working parents are still able to go places and enjoy their summer."**
>
> - Parent

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Post-Program Action

Lack of Program-District Communication

Nearly all program coordinators emphasized that what's discussed during planning meetings often diverges significantly from what unfolds on the ground.

Many noted that **unless district Staff physically visit program sites**, **they cannot fully understand operational realities** such as curriculum misalignment, resource gaps, or shifting student needs.

In an 8th grade math class at an enrichment program, only five students were present. The instructor—who teaches high school math at another school—shared:

> **I hardly use this provided curriculum. It's just too hard for the kids. It's completely two different levels. If I didn't have a strong background in math instruction, I wouldn't know what to do."**
>
> - Field Note

Post-Program Action (cont.)

Limited Family Feedback

Among all 18 programs, only a few had developed a formal process for gathering input from families. **Most relied on passive methods, such as waiting for parents to approach staff if concerns arose.**

Without structured tools for collecting feedback—such as surveys, reflection forms, or family exit interviews—valuable insights into program satisfaction and impact are lost.



SummerQuest final showcase at Shortlidge Academy. Family was invited to participate in classes.

Insight

-Promising Practices

Promising Practices

Amid the challenges identified across planning, execution, and post-program reflection, several programs stood out for implementing effective practices that enhanced coordination, engagement, and overall impact.

The key themes that emerged include:

Regular Communication Between Program, Family, and District

Understanding Students' Unique Needs and Avoiding One-Size-Fits All Approaches

Interconnected, Project-Based Curriculum

Balance of Academic and Enrichment Activities

Family and Community Engagement

External Partnership and Collaboration

Call to Action

-Recommendations and Next Steps for the Wilmington Learning Collaborative

Engagement Model for WLC

The WLC engagement model aims to **reposition summer learning as an intentional, year-round initiative** rather than a reactive, short-term effort. By grounding planning in data and sustained stakeholder engagement, WLC can ensure its summer programs are better aligned with student needs, operational realities, and long-term educational goals.

Engagement Model for WLC		
Program Stage	**Timeline**	**Goal**
Pre-Program Planning	Previous Spring Semester	Support districts and schools in providing early visibility of summer learning programs to families
	End of previous summer (August - September)	Evaluate prior summer and allocate funding
	August - October	Establish visions and goals
Program Planning	November - December	Plan and develop programs for PreK-5th grade students
		Plan and develop programs for middle and high school students
Program Communication	December - February	Support districts and schools with summer program marketing and recruitment efforts
Program Enrollment and Attendance	February - May	Establish recourse options for different scenarios related to student attendance
Program Execution	May - August	Monitor in real-time and adjust responsively
Post-Program Review & Feedback	September - October	Understand impact and plan for improvement

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Call to Action

-Recommendations and Next Steps for Partners

Recommendations and Next Steps for Partners

As schools, districts, and community organizations plan and execute summer learning programs, four strategic priorities can help address the recurring challenges of low student attendance and limited engagement:

Start Planning Earlier

Foster Cross-Functional Communication

Extend Programming Length and Hours & Address Transportation Issues

Balance Academic Instruction with Enrichment Activities

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Call to Action

-Shared Recommendations

Key Performance Indicators (KPIs)

A clearly defined set of Key Performance Indicators (KPIs) will provide the WLC, schools and district leaders with measurable metrics to assess program effectiveness and demonstrate the impact of funding efforts, helping to guide planning and decision-making for future summers.

Key Performance Indicators (KPIs)		
Goal	**Metric Name**	**Description**
Demonstrate measurable improvement in core academic areas.	**Academic Progress**	Measures academic growth and literacy skills through pre- and post-program assessment data.
Increase average daily student daily attendance to match industry standard of 75%.	**Student Engagement**	Utilize average daily student attendance to reflect student engagement.
Achieve ≥85% satisfaction rating from both students and families.	**Student and Family Satisfaction**	Captures feedback from students on their summer experience and perceived learning, along with post-program input from families.
Ensure representation reflects district demographics; increase inclusion of special needs students by 10%.	**Program Inclusion**	Analyzes student demographics, including age, gender, race/ethnicity, and the number of students with special needs participating in the program.
Maintain or reduce cost per participant while preserving program quality.	**Cost Per Participant**	Calculates program cost efficiency by dividing total program funding by the average daily student attendance.

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Lingering Questions

Lingering Questions

There is no one-size-fits-all solution to summer learning. This study was designed to elevate on-the-ground insights, but it also uncovered important gaps that warrant further exploration. Continuous data collection, real-time evaluation, and long-term investment in understanding summer learning systems will be key to ensuring all students are engaged, supported, and learning year-round.

To strengthen and reimagine summer learning, the following questions can help guide planning and decision-making:

Target Audience and Program Design

Who is the intended focus of summer learning in terms of:

- Program length
- Daily schedule
- Content and type of activities
- Feedback gathered from staff, families, and students

Lingering Questions (cont.)

Summer Programming at Non-WLC Schools

What does summer learning look like in non-WLC schools with regard to:

- Program offerings
- Program length
- Daily schedule
- Curriculum/content
- Funding sources/total funding
- Attendance rates
- Differences between Title I and non–Title I schools

Sponsored Programs

For sponsored programs (e.g., Freedom School, YMCA, 21st Century), how closely do they align with:

- Their respective national models or proposals
- Implementation at other schools
- Identified model sites and best practices

Lingering Questions (cont.)

Measuring Impact

- How is the impact of summer learning measured by data?
- What does data-driven education mean in this context?
- What metrics are used to evaluate effectiveness?
- How might we reimagine summer learning as an intentional extension of the school year—both academically and operationally?

Fiscal Stewardship and Attendance

- If district leaders choose to extend the length of summer programs in future years, how does that reflect sound fiscal stewardship, especially given historically low attendance rates?

Report by Franklin Cheng

Strategic Support Fellow

For questions, please email franklin@wlc-de.org.

WLC